

the English Opera Group as a touring company performing chamber operas, and the following year founded the Aldeburgh Festival (see box). His status in British music was reflected by the Royal Opera House's staging his *Gloriana* to mark the coronation of Queen Elizabeth II in 1953, although the opera proved too dark and challenging to satisfy celebratory expectations.



RUSSIAN FRIENDSHIP

The Russian cellist Mstislav Rostropovich (left) grasps Britten's hand, after playing the composer's Cello Sonata in his Aldeburgh music room. Russian soprano Galina Vishnevskaya and Swiss conductor Paul Sacher applaud in the background.

Popularity and innovation

Despite his growing fame, Britten's sexuality kept him nervous of the police, who were conducting a virulent campaign against high-placed homosexuals in the early 1950s. He was rendered vulnerable not only by his relationship with Pears but by the attraction he felt for adolescent boys. These personal tensions